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Take your PowerShell to the next level with error handling and debugging

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Jane Street

About Me

- Solution Architect @ FM
- Focus on Infrastructure Atuomation (With PowerShell of course)
- Long time listener, first time presenter

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Error Handling and Debugging with PowerShell

https://www.youtube.com/@PowershellOrg

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The $Error variable

- $Error is an automatic array variable that stores all error records from the current PowerShell session, with the most recent error at index 0.
- Can also use Get-Error
- In try/catch blocks, $_ represents the current error
- $? - Did the last command succeed - true/false
- $Error.Clear()- Clears the error history for the current session

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Demo

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Terminating Errors

- Terminating Errors
  - Stops the pipeline/script immediately unless caught (try/catch)
- Non-Terminating Errors
  - Writes to the error stream then continues execution
- The ultimate Terminator: Throw()

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$ErrorActionPreference

- Variable which defines how PowerShell should respond to Non-Terminating Errors
- Can be configured on a command by command basis using: -ErrorAction

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Terminating Errors

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Try/Catch

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Throw() vs. Write-Error

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	throw()	Write-Error
Error Type	Terminating	Non-Terminating (by default)
Stops Execution	✅Always	❌No (by default)
Stops Pipeline	✅Yes	❌No (continues to next input object)
Catchable wiith try/catch	✅Always	❌Only with -ErrorAction Stop
Writes to error stream	✅Yes	✅Yes
Typical Use	Fatal / Unrecoverable conditions	Recoverable / Per-item failures

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Demo

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